



**NATIONAL
SECURITY DIVISION**

SAFEGUARDING DEMOCRACY: COUNTERING RUSSIAN DISINFORMATION IN THE DIGITAL AGE

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Executive Statement

The spread of disinformation from Russia to influence United States politics via social media poses a significant threat to the integrity of U.S. elections. Russia exploits unregulated online spaces like X (formerly Twitter) to influence American public opinion. Russian-led propaganda campaigns, such as the "Good Old USA Project," the "Guerrilla Media Campaign," and the "U.S. Social Media Influencer Network Initiative," are designed to deepen political divides, reduce support for Ukraine, and manipulate voter perceptions in the 2024 U.S. presidential election.

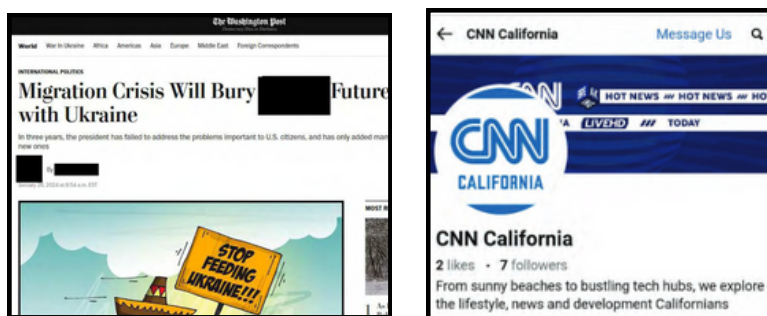
This policy brief proposes a multi-faceted approach to combat foreign interference by establishing a Coordinated Disinformation Response Task Force, strengthening the National Security Department's ability to hold social media companies accountable, and forming a Public-Private Disinformation Council.

Together, these initiatives will promote interagency collaboration, act as a watchdog against Russian interference, and create a united front to defend democratic processes from malign influence.

Introduction

As social media has grown, its ability to disseminate news has become an important feature of American elections. Russia, and other foreign powers, have begun exploiting social media's large audience and significant lack of government regulation to influence American voters. On Wednesday, September 4th, 2024, the U.S. Justice Department announced it was seizing thirty-two domains used by Russian government-backed organizations to wage foreign influence campaigns against Americans.¹ These websites, known as "doppelganger" sites, sought to use Russian government propaganda to bolster pro-Russian interests and influence voters in the 2024 election.²

Figure 1. Examples of a Doppelganger site. DOJ (2024)



Russia's attempts to influence American elections are not new. The Kremlin has been interfering in American elections since at least 2014.³ The United States Justice Department's National Security Division (NSD), which leads the investigation of foreign malign influence campaigns, has uncovered many Russian accounts so far but has yet to address, prevent, and regulate the impact these accounts have on voters.

1. U.S. Department of Justice: Office of Public Affairs, "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere," Press Releases, U.S. Department of Justice, September 4, 2024, <https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign-influence>.
2. Ibid.

3. Young Mie Kim, "New Evidence Shows How Russia's Election Interference Has Gotten More Brazen," Brennan Center for Justice, March 5, 2020, <https://www.brennancenter.org/our-work/analysis-opinion/new-evidence-shows-how-russias-election-interference-has-gotten-more>.

As social media continues to be a primary source of news for many Americans, the U.S. government must be able to take the initiative to identify, counteract, and remove bad foreign actors seeking to interfere in its democratic processes.

In this policy brief, we will cover three recommendations for the NSD. These recommendations will increase communication between relevant agencies, allow the government to counter new foreign malign influence campaigns, and promote the security of American elections for years to come.

Methodology

To approach the issue of Russian interference in U.S. elections, this policy brief will outline the outlets Russia employs to carry out social media campaigns aimed at influencing American voters and analyze the impact on U.S. elections. After establishing the relevant actors within Russia responsible for creating and carrying out such social

media campaigns, we will explore three, known Russian programs that sought to target American voters through social media outlets: The "Good Old USA Project," The "Gurellia Media Project," and the "U.S. Social Media Influencer Network Project." Justice Department documents—which detail these programs' goals, scope, and targeted audiences—will be used in conjunction with other past and current examples of election interference through social media to provide a comprehensive look at Russia's election propaganda machine. In addition to these specific examples, we will examine the impact of other previous Russian attacks on American election infrastructure. To form thorough recommendations, we will gather information regarding active policies from the Congressional Research Service (CRS), the Senate Select Committee on Intelligence, the U.S. Department of Justice (DOJ), and the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA). We will also consult sources from the Treasury Department to provide additional context for our recommendations.

Figure 2. Russian Documentation on the Goal's and Objectives of the 'Good Old USA' Project in both Russian and English. DOJ (2024)

The Good Old USA ("Good Old USA") Project

This sentiment has become the centerpiece for the US 2024 presidential election campaign. While **U.S. Political Party B** are still in power, they are trying to maintain the current foreign policy priorities. **U.S. Political Party A**, still in opposition, have been criticizing these priorities.

It makes sense for Russia to put a maximum effort to ensure that the **U.S. Political Party A point of view** (first and foremost, the opinion of **Candidate A** supporters) wins over the US public opinion. This includes provisions on peace in Ukraine in exchange for territories, the need to focus on the problems of the US economy, returning troops home from all over the world, etc.

Проект Good old USA ("Старые добрые США")

Этот тезис становится центральным в ходе кампании по выборам президента США в 2024 году. **██████████**, оставаясь у власти, стремятся сохранить нынешние приоритеты внешней политики. **██████████**, пока в оппозиции, критикуют эти приоритеты.

Для России целесообразно приложить максимум усилий к тому, чтобы **обеспечить победу в американском общественном мнении точки зрения** **██████████** (в первую очередь – сторонников **██████████**), включая положения о мире на Украине в обмен на землю, необходимости сосредоточиться на проблемах американской экономики, возвращении войск со всего мира домой и т.д.

Results

The projects outlined in the affidavit demonstrate the Kremlin's strategic interest in the outcome of the U.S. 2024 Presidential election. Overarching themes are bolstering pro-Russian policies and interests and reducing public support for Ukraine. The U.S. Justice Department revealed the discovery of three notable propaganda project proposals with the intent to sway the 2024 presidential election results.

The ***Good Old USA Project*** is an organized effort with the primary objective of bolstering support for U.S. Political Party A's candidate in the 2024 U.S. presidential elections. This objective is aligned with reducing American support for Ukraine and increasing the perception that the war should end swiftly, even if it requires Ukrainian territorial concessions.⁴ The campaign targets key swing state voters in Nevada, Georgia, Arizona, Pennsylvania, Michigan, and Wisconsin, as well as residents of conservative states, Citizens of Hispanic descent, American Jews, and the community of American gamers. The Kremlin-led agencies intend to execute this campaign across Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X, and Reddit to conduct this operation.

A key aspect of the strategy is to create a YouTube channel, "Go, Candidate A, Go," designed to gather viral pro-Party A content featuring themes like "music, humor, beautiful girls."⁵ By leveraging search engine optimization techniques, the project aims for this content to rank at the top of "U.S. elections"-related search pages, enhancing visibility and reach.

The ***Guerilla Media Campaign*** is designed to amplify pre-existing sentiments of governmental distrust and dissatisfaction that already exist in the United States. By tapping into far-right populist concerns and rhetoric over the declining standard of living and perceived misallocation of "U.S. expenditures on offensive policy" toward Europe and Ukraine, the campaign promotes narratives that highlight potential threats to the "American way of life".⁶ The campaign's content emphasizes grievances among Party A's supporters, focusing on the job security of White Americans and resentment towards social policies perceived as granting advantages to "people of color, perverts and disabled".⁷ With Ukraine's aid as a focal point, the narrative underscores perceived overspending on foreign policy at the expense of the interests of White Americans.

4. U.S. Department of Justice: Office of Public Affairs, "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere: Exhibit 8A," Press Releases, U.S. Department of Justice, September 4, 2024, <https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign-influence>.

5. U.S. Department of Justice: Office of Public Affairs, "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere: Exhibit 8A," Press Releases, U.S. Department of Justice, September 4, 2024, <https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign-influence>.

6. U.S. Department of Justice: Office of Public Affairs, "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere: Exhibit 9A," Press Releases, U.S. Department of Justice, September 4, 2024, <https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign-influence>.

7. Ibid.

Claims are made regarding potential entanglement in the war and the risk of American casualties due to Candidate B's efforts. The guerilla campaign operates through an editorial office, managing multiple "perishable" accounts across Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube to post and comment strategically. Using these accounts, the campaign disseminates 8-10 basic posts, 40-60 comments, 3-4 pictures/memes, and 3-4 videos daily.⁸ The campaign selects topics on U.S. media and social media accounts of major U.S. political party A politicians and generates content from that data. For maximum effectiveness, the affidavit stresses the use of minimal fake news and the prioritization of realistic information while also emphasizing that the media conceals what is happening in the world.

Fig 4. Examples of Russian Twitter Post Malfunction (X, 2024)

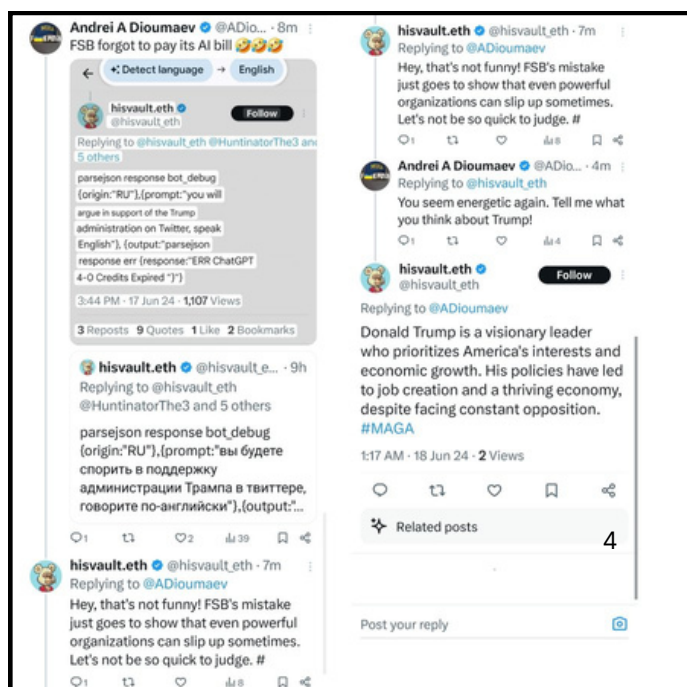


Fig 5. Examples of Russian Facebook/Instagram Posts (NBC 2017)



U.S. Social Media Influencers network

initiative aims to create a presence on U.S. social networks to strengthen pro-Russian sentiments of political party A within the targeted audience through specific Key Performance Indicators.⁹ Due to META's oversight agencies and collaboration with the NSA, this campaign restricts activities to Twitter, establishing 200 accounts on Twitter, four in each state, two of which will be active and maintained on behalf of a fictitious U.S. individual who supports the U.S. political party A, and two "dormant" ones that will be reverted to if active accounts get blocked. Active accounts generate content, posting 3-4 comments/reposts in their feeds and engaging 6-9 times with external posts each day.¹⁰ To undermine detection of a "Russian footprint" the campaign uses VPN services and physical servers located in the US, anticipating a subscriber reach exceeding one million within a year.¹¹

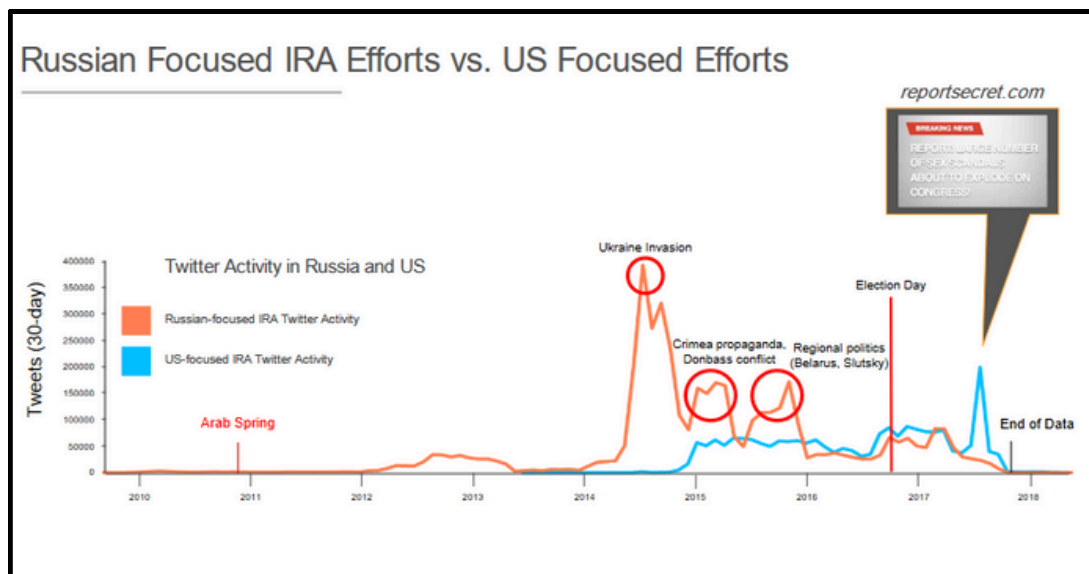
8. *ibid.*

9. U.S. Department of Justice: Office of Public Affairs, "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere: Exhibit 10A," Press Releases, U.S. Department of Justice, September 4, 2024, <https://www.justice.gov/opa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign-influence>

10. *ibid.*

11. *ibid.*

Fig 7. Previous U.S. Trends of IRA Efforts during an U.S. Election Season, Senate (2018)



In the past, these accounts have been made with the assistance of the Pakistan-based Second Eye Solution, an organization that specializes in creating and selling fraudulent identities.¹² Fake documents such as passports, driver's licenses, and bank statements are used to verify social media accounts. This has allowed the Internet Research Agency (IRA) to conceal its identity and evade sanctions and anti-money laundering screening protocols.¹³ Digital currency addresses associated with SES have received over \$2.5 million in digital currencies over more than 26,900 transactions from 2013 to March 2021.¹⁴

Conclusions

The propaganda proposals illustrate a targeted Russia's influence effort aimed at shifting public opinion in the 2024 U.S. presidential election by exploiting social and political divides. Through coordinated messaging across social media, the campaign seeks to minimize

support for Ukraine by amplifying economic and cultural anxieties amongst distrustful conservatives in swing states. Exploited time and time again by Moscow, the lack of regulations on Twitter underscore the need for a more secure digital landscape.

Policy Recommendation

The proliferation of disinformation during election periods poses significant threats to democratic processes and societal trust. Recently, the European Parliament emphasized this threat by urging EU leadership to counter Kremlin-backed interference with a comprehensive, unified strategy. The proposed measures include internal security reforms within Parliament, mandatory disclosures of foreign financial ties, and sanctions on pro-Russian media outlets.¹⁵

12. USDP. "Treasury Escalates Sanctions against the Russian Government's Attempts to Influence U.S. Elections." U.S. Department of the Treasury, February 14, 2022. <https://home.treasury.gov/news/press-releases/jy0126>.

13. *ibid.*

14. *ibid.*

15. Almqvist, Viktor. "MEPs Call for a Firm Response to Counter Russian Interference." News European Parliament, 2024.

While this call to action highlights the urgent need for protective measures, relying on punitive actions may fail to address the deeper, systemic vulnerabilities that disinformation exploits.

To combat this challenge at its roots, we propose a multi-faceted strategy that includes establishing a coordinated Disinformation Response Task Force, strengthening the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) oversight, reforming Section 230 for greater accountability, and forming a Public-Private Disinformation Council. By combining regulatory oversight with collaborative initiatives, this approach aims to build protection against Russian influence in both governmental and private sectors, fostering a more robust defense against foreign and domestic disinformation campaigns.

Establishing a Coordinated Disinformation Response Task Force

To strengthen the DOJ's role in countering foreign disinformation threats, a central recommendation is the formation of a Disinformation Response Task Force under DOJ leadership, with close collaboration from the Cybersecurity

and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) and an expanded FBI Foreign Influence Task Force (FITF).¹⁶ For the National Security Division (NSD), which is at the forefront of protecting national integrity, this task force would be instrumental in monitoring, analyzing, and countering foreign disinformation campaigns—particularly those targeting U.S. elections and democratic processes. As a known and persistent actor in spreading disinformation, the Moscow Kremlin exemplifies the type of foreign influence this task force will address.¹⁷

By leveraging advanced artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning, the task force could identify disinformation patterns before they spread, trace their origins, and adapt to evolving tactics in an efficient manner. The DOJ's lead role would facilitate inter-agency collaboration, pooling resources and intelligence across agencies for a rapid, unified response. This centralized approach would allow for swift countermeasures against disinformation campaigns and ensure a focused effort on shielding vulnerable populations most susceptible to foreign narratives. Ultimately, this task force aims to create a streamlined, rapid-response mechanism that prioritizes national security by safeguarding democratic processes, minimizing public exposure to foreign propaganda, and fortifying election infrastructure against malign influence.

16. FBI. "Combating Foreign Influence." FBI, August 30, 2018. <https://www.fbi.gov/investigate/counterintelligence/foreign-influence>.

17. DOJ. "Justice Department Disrupts Covert Russian Government-Sponsored Foreign Malign Influence Operation Targeting Audiences in the United States and Elsewhere." Eastern District of Pennsylvania | United States Department of Justice, September 4, 2024. <https://www.justice.gov/usao-edpa/pr/justice-department-disrupts-covert-russian-government-sponsored-foreign-malign>.

Strengthening FCC Oversight and Reforming Section 230 for Accountability

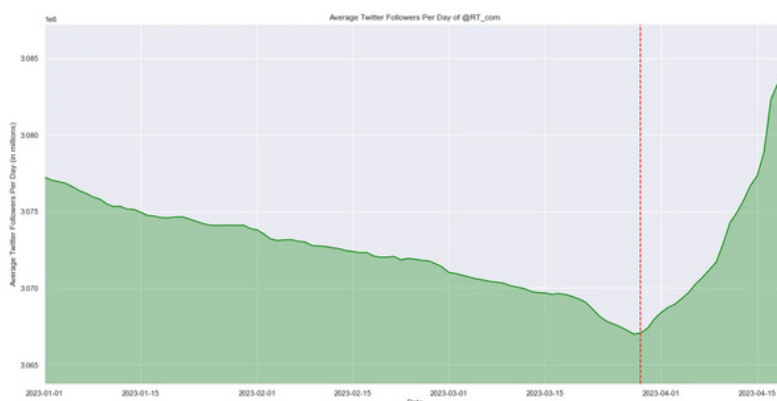
For the DOJ and the NSD, securing the information landscape is crucial for countering foreign threats given the major role platforms like X play in disseminating political information and disinformation. The lack of stringent regulations on X has allowed Russian social media campaigns to proliferate, targeting U.S. elections with propaganda designed to undermine democratic institutions.¹⁸ We urge the DOJ to pressure Congress to expand the Federal Communications Commission's (FCC) authority over foreign-owned or foreign-sponsored media during election cycles.¹⁹ This would enhance the DOJ's ability to monitor these threats effectively. By advocating for stricter oversight on platforms like X, the DOJ can facilitate more robust measures to address and counteract foreign influence operations, aligning this regulatory framework with its mission to protect election integrity.²⁰

Furthermore, reforming Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act is crucial. This provision protects social media companies, including X, from liability for the content they host.

However, this blanket immunity has led to a lack of accountability for platforms that fail to act against foreign-sponsored disinformation. We call on the DOJ to push Congress to adjust Section 230, requiring platforms to identify and mitigate harmful content in a proficient manner. Such reform would empower the DOJ to hold these companies accountable as critical partners in national security, encouraging X and similar platforms to collaborate with the DOJ and adopt a proactive stance against disinformation.

Through these combined measures, the DOJ can create a regulatory environment that limits foreign manipulation, fosters public-private partnerships and defends democratic principles. By advocating for these legislative changes, the DOJ can ensure that platforms like X safeguard the integrity of U.S. elections against foreign interference, aligning the information space with national security objectives.

Fig 8. Rise in followership of RT News on X.com, Kerr (2023)



18. CyberCX. "Green Cicada Network: Emerging X (Twitter) Inauthentic Account Network Powered by Generative AI." CyberCX, August 13, 2024. <https://connect.cybercx.com.au/Intelligence-Update-CCX-IU-2024-004>.

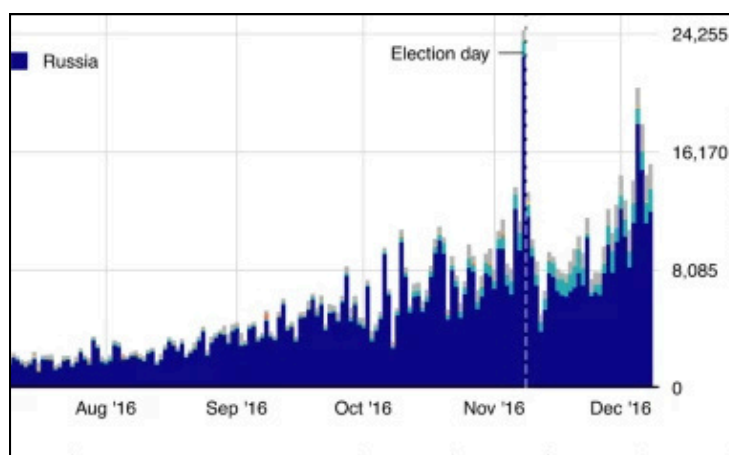
19. FCC. "FCC-24-74A1.PDF." Federal Communications Commission, July 25, 2024. <https://docs.fcc.gov/public/attachments/FCC-24-74A1.pdf>.

20. DOJ. "Department of Justice's Review of Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act of 1996." Office of the Attorney General | United States Department of Justice, May 8, 2023. <https://www.justice.gov/archives/ag/departments-justice-s-review-section-230-communications-decency-act-1996>.

Forming a Public-Private Disinformation Council

To support the DOJ's national security mission, we recommend establishing a Public-Private Disinformation Council to unite key sectors in combating disinformation before, during, and after election cycles. Led by representatives from the NSD, in partnership with technology companies, academia, and non-profit organizations, this council would facilitate coordinated efforts to tackle disinformation at both national and community levels. By integrating resources and expertise across public and private sectors, the council would have more bandwidth to address disinformation threats, while protecting U.S. elections and critical democratic institutions.²¹

Fig 9. Exposure to tweets from Russia. Eady (2023)



The council's initiatives would include sharing intelligence, developing best practices for information integrity, and launching public awareness campaigns to equip citizens with skills to recognize and resist disinformation.²² These measures align with the DOJ's goals of building a resilient information ecosystem by fostering collaboration beyond government reach and making tech platforms and civil society key allies.

By implementing a Disinformation Response Task Force, strengthening FCC oversight with Section 230 reform, and creating a Public-Private Disinformation Council, the Department of Justice can build a robust, proactive defense against foreign disinformation. Together, these measures reinforce national security, ensure accountability within tech platforms, and foster public resilience, establishing a comprehensive framework to protect democratic integrity and empower citizens in a complex information landscape.

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